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Communication Plan

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Overview

This document contains the strategies and goals for dissemination and promotion of the ISARIC Clinical Epidemiology platform (“ISARIC Data Tools”) according to the ISARIC’s program to support researchers and studies related to infectious diseases.

Introduction

The ISARIC Clinical Epidemiology (CE) platform aims to support people worldwide, enabling an environment where clinical research is conducted globally and in an agile response to infectious disease. Among key elements, the ISARIC CE platform has the responsibility to provide tools to support clinical research allowing the studies of infectious diseases to be conducted quickly and providing quality evidence.

Following the idea of disseminating ISARIC's Data Tools, this document focused on how to reach the audience, keep them engaged, and encourage them to adopt the available ISARIC CE resources. In the following, you will find the necessary information about the audience, phases of the dissemination plan, and communications channels.

1. The Audience

The ISARIC CE platform offers a variety of tools and resources to assist research for different users, which present their own needs and require targeted communication and dissemination actions. To ensure the right perspective of this communication plan, two main target audiences are considered.

- 1) Those involved in clinical research that will apply ISARIC data tools and methods to their studies to generate evidence and insights, which are identified as “non-developers”. This audience comprises non-technical users, such as the principal investigators, those with clinical background only and stakeholders.

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2) Those interested in software development (i.e., to extend the use of tools, create new analytical methodologies, or improve the existing tools accordingly), identified as the “developers” audience. These comprise of data managers, data analysis or data scientists, software developers, those with technical background. This audience will find the proper information and guidance on the GitHub platform¹.

Additionally, this plan assumes that it may not be possible to identify the audience in most cases, as new users will come from diverse sources, such as events and conferences, email contact, referrals/indications, training sessions, and online search.

2. Phases of dissemination plan

This section covers the three phases of this dissemination plan. The main idea behind promoting a plan in phases consists of the possibility of feedback from the previous phase helping with small adjustments whether necessary to engage the audience in the best way possible. To comprehend the phases Figure 1 provides phases relations and communication flow.

Figure 1 – Phases relationship and communication flow.



Source: Created by ISARIC HUB South America, 2025.

¹ ISARIC platform on GitHub: <https://github.com/ISARICResearch>

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As we can see in Figure 1, each phase will communicate as a feedback process providing the board of ISARIC to decide whether a tool or method will take place on the following phase, avoiding audience disengagement, and discontinuation of tools usage.

As of this date, we identified some information regarding the use and adoption of existing ISARIC CE tools. This non-official information was obtained from an expert judgment, and it can be seen as a starting point of the dissemination plan. The data available on Table 1 shows the information of studies and tools separated by infectious disease study.

Table 1 – Current state of tools usage and partners location (June 2025)

Infections Disease Studies	Location	Partners	Tools in use
Dengue	Nepal, Pakistan, India, Sri Lanka, and Brazil	26 partners in Critical Care Asia network and 2 in Brazil. Total of 28 partners.	ARC, BRIDGE and VERTEX
mPox	Democratic Republic of the Congo	2 partners at Democratic Republic of the Congo.	ARC, BRIDGE and VERTEX
Nipah	Bangladesh	3 partners in Bangladesh	VERTEX
Oropuche	Brazil	1 partner (also included in Dengue studies)	ARC and BRIDGE

Source: Created by ISARIC HUB South America, 2025.

2.1. Phase one: ISARIC Engagement

The first phase of dissemination of the ISARIC CE Platform is called Engagement. In this phase, the following activities will be performed:

- 1) Creation of communication plan and approval from ISARIC Board Members.
- 2) Identifying the researchers' profiles who utilize the tools related to their clinical studies in the ISARIC network.

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- a) Research profile will consist of name, age, sex, occupation, academic degree, email, tools in use, demographic location, connected to the hub, ORCID, and expected use of the tools.
- 3) Development of a dashboard of profile research data to understand who is involved in the use of tools.
- 4) Creations of a user guide containing explanations about how to use tools.
- 5) Email onboarding about ISARIC tools to researchers in South America and Asia.
 - a) A pilot focusing on Dengue research will be conducted to validate the onboarding process for the program.
 - b) The onboarding will contain general information related to how to use the tools (starter kit).
- 6) Creation of email as “contact us to help” providing assistance to users' questions about the tool utilization and limitations.

The expected outcomes are to support end users in the tool adoption process and understand the user's profile.

2.2. Phase two: ISARIC Expansion

The second phase was named Expansion, the main objective is to expand the support for clinical studies not contemplated in phase one and increase the number of tools' users worldwide (including non-ISARIC partners). This phase covers the actions below:

- 1) Maintenance of actions performed in phase 1.
- 2) Update of a user guide containing explanations about how to use tools.
 - a) Each tool will have one guide with the version and date of the last revision.
- 3) Publication of user's guide on ISARIC's web page.
- 4) Publication of Q&A page on ISARIC's official website related to most common questions collected from phase one.

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- 5) Adoption of a bi-monthly newsletter to inform tools about new releases, bug fixes, improvements, and publication of studies using the tools.
 - a) Due to rights, the publication of studies in the newsletter requires the express consent of the publisher.
- 6) Promotion of tools using banners and abstracts in at least two national congresses in South America Hub.

In this phase, the outcome will be the increase of members using the tools.

2.3. Phase three: ISARIC Community

This is the moment of consolidating ISARIC tools usage and adoption. The third phase will consist of the creation of a community where the levels of interaction between hubs and users will increase and become organic. It will also allow newcomers of any hub to join the ISARIC program in different forms.

- 1) Creation of the community guideline and publish it among ISARIC's members.
- 2) Setup of a communication tool to provide real-time interactions grouped by subject.
 - a) A subject can be related to the type of infectious disease, methodology, or tool itself.
- 3) Development of a business intelligence dashboard providing insights to board members about users and researchers at ISARICs community.
- 4) Promotion of ISARICs program in an annual event about the application of tools and research results.
 - a) The annual event can have attendees online and in person.
 - b) Every year the event will take place in a different hub.
- 5) Creation of online courses related to techniques, tools utilization, best practices using an online video platform.

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- 6) Creation of the community multichannel using communication tools, events, and business intelligence to provide continuous communication and dissemination of tools provided by ISARIC's platform.

The main objective of the third phase is the consolidation of tools dissemination in a community where the flow of information increases, and everyone involved in the program can promote the tools, platform features, and ISARIC program.

3. Communication Channels and Technology

To perform all the three phases contemplated in previous sections of this document, it is necessary to define the channels and technologies required for the process. The current section provides a brief description of channels and technologies that are considered to perform all activities and achieve the purpose of each phase.

- Google Workspace for Business²: an email account is required to communicate and answer questions related to tools and their functionalities.
- Google Meet², Zoom³, or MS Teams⁴: digital communication tools used on meetings or events with the intention of having a one-one meeting or one-to-many meeting to provide insights and useful information to those using the tools.
- Slack⁵ or Discord: an instant message tool providing separation by channels and real time conversations. The tool will be used as a community communication platform, and it was

² Google Workspace for Business: <https://workspace.google.com/>

³ Zoom: <https://www.zoom.com/>

⁴ MS Teams: <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-teams/group-chat-software/>

⁵ Slack: <https://slack.com/>

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evaluated⁶ as a proper tool for management and community engagement using the Gartner Magic Quadrant⁷.

- Mailchimp⁸: massive communication to perform a bi-monthly newsletter.
- Power BI⁹ or Shiny¹⁰: a business intelligence platform to analyze data and generate insightful information to stakeholders and decision managers.
- Udemy¹¹: an online platform to create courses related to techniques, tools applications and best practices.

Each tool provides an opportunity for knowledge, but it also represents an investment and requires availability from suppliers. In this case, HUB South America would replace one technology that maintains the same quality of communication and with the commitment to delivering the activities previously described.

3.1. Methodology and communication flow

The methodology will be passive (email, dashboards and newsletter) and active (meetings, instant messaging, and events) according to each method and the technology applied case by case. Table 2 details the type of information, target audience, frequency, and communication method for each item in the plan. Hub South America will be responsible for designing the communication plan and providing feedback on its effectiveness.

Table 2 – Communication types and methods.

What information	Target Audience	When?	Method of Communication
Research profile and tools usage	Coordinators, sponsors and board members.	Monthly.	Online interaction.

⁶ Slack on Gartner Magic Quadrant: <https://www.gartner.com/reviews/market/workplace-social-software/vendor/salesforce-slack/product/slack>

⁷ Gartner Magic Quadrant: <https://www.gartner.com/en/research/methodologies/magic-quadrants-research>

⁸ Mailchimp: <https://mailchimp.com/>

⁹ Power BI: <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/power-platform>

¹⁰ Shiny BI: <https://shiny.posit.co/>

¹¹ Udemy: <https://www.udemy.com/>

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Onboarding about the program.	Anyone interested in ISARIC tools.	By demand.	Email, onboarding the person about the program and use.
Supports about tool utilization	Anyone interested in ISARIC tools.	By demand.	Email answering general questions
Specific support for tool application.	Person with specific questions related to tools.	By demand.	Online meeting to clarify the comprehension and utilization.
User guides.	Anyone interested in ISARIC tools.	Available online	Download from ISARIC web page.
Common questions and answers.	Anyone interested in ISARIC tools.	Available online	Accessed on ISARIC web page.
Tools updates, events, studies, and opportunities.	Anyone interested in ISARIC tools and program.	Bi-monthly	Sending through massive communication tool.
Community guidelines	Any person joined the community in the instant communication tool.	By demand	Email with the community guide and on community subscription.
Promotion of tools and presentation of cases of success	Participants of annual event	Annually at the event.	In person and online meetings, panel of discussion, and paper presentations.
News about events, tools usage, new releases, online courses, and online meetings.	Members of ISARIC CE platform.	By demand.	Online interaction.

Source: Created by ISARIC HUB South America, 2025.

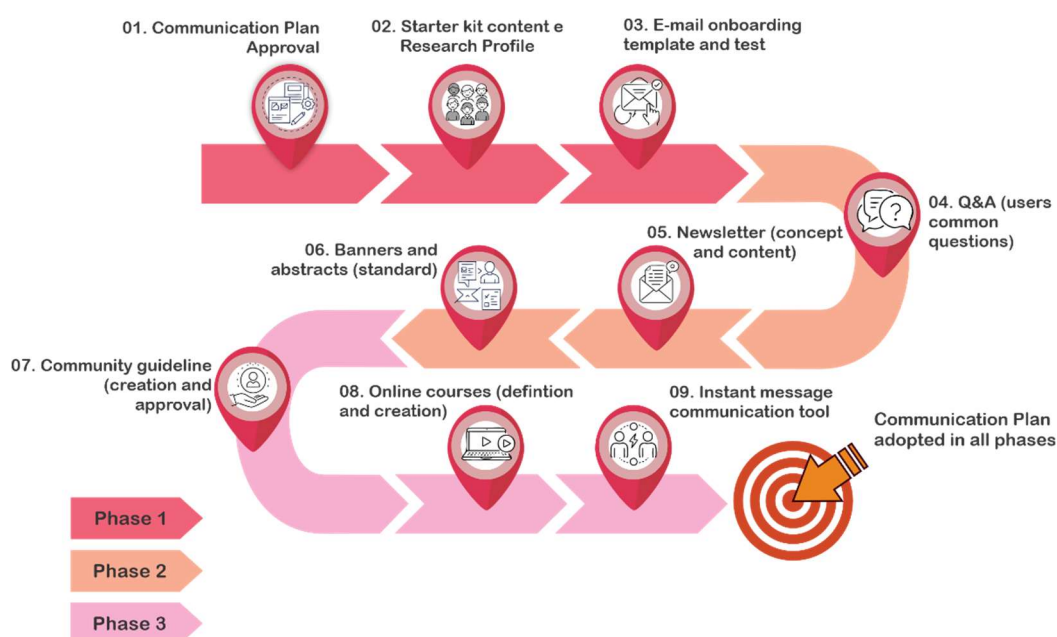
All activities and applications of this communication plan, and any modifications will be submitted to appropriate approval to reflect the steps necessary to ensure the correct use of tools and proper adoption of studies related to infectious diseases.

4. Roadmap

The set of activities and all related phases will be adopted following approval, with any necessary modifications made as required. The communication plan does not include a calendar of activities; instead, it features a roadmap in Figure 2 that outlines the steps for all activities included in this plan.

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Figure 2 – Communication plan adoption roadmap.



Source: Created by ISARIC HUB South America, 2025.

4.1. Communication Plan Approval

A set of activities are related to this sub-phase related to communication plan approval:

- Design of the strategic communication plan for tools dissemination.
- Plan review and feedback.
- Plan approval.

4.2. Starter kit and research profile

After approval, the starter kit and research profile are the main activities to be prioritized. The first one will provide some guidance to those requesting information on how to be involved, how to use tools and a calendar of ISARIC events. For instance, for a site or a researcher interested in joining one of ISARIC research studies at the moment, a package of materials including information on how to access the ISARIC CE Platform resources', training guides and contact information, will be provided. The second one can provide information to understand research needs, connect

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them to appropriate networks (HUBs and partners), and generate insights from ISARIC decision makers to create more value to them.

- Define the content for each starter kit.
- Define a template for the starter kit.
- Approve the starter kit content and template
- Collect information from the user's profile.
- Create a dashboard using user profile data.

4.3. E-mail onboarding template and test

The email onboarding process for those interested in tools or connecting on the ISARIC platform should have a formal structure to consistently convey a clear and friendly message.

- Define email content.
- Create a template for the email.
- Test the template format and content.
- Define the internal process of using this email.

4.4. Q&A page

The idea of a question and answers page is to identify the most frequent topics users have been asking, thus avoiding the necessity of using email or waiting for a proper response.

- Define Q&A content.
- Develop the Q&A page.
- Deploy the Q&A page.
- Approve the Q&A page.
- Define a revision process for Q&A.

4.5. Newsletter

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A newsletter is a useful tool for sharing news and events within the ISARIC community. Adopting a newsletter will keep members informed about important facts related to the consortium.

- Decide about a separate or integrated newsletter (tools only).
- Outline the newsletter content about tools.
- Define the regularity of the newsletter.
- Design newsletter.
- Send a newsletter to the audience.

4.6. Banners and abstracts

Banners and abstracts will be used in congress and events to quickly inform attendees about the existence and purpose of ISARIC tools.

- Define banner layout and content.
- Inform the DOI of the tools.
- Create instructions on how and when to use the tools.

4.7. Community guideline

A community fosters new possibilities and enhances communication efficiency and frequency. Community guidelines help institutions moderate inappropriate behavior and clearly define acceptable channels within the online community.

- Create guideline content.
- Verify local restrictions in accordance with the legislation.
- Choose content moderators.
- Write the community guidelines.
- Approve community guidelines across all HUBs.

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4.8. Online courses

Online courses focused on data science as they refer to studying outbreaks can effectively engage and reach a broad audience. These courses will cover relevant data science content and will also showcase the capabilities of various tools as valuable opportunities for participants.

- Define content creators.
- Create presentation templates.
- Outline courses contents.
- Record online courses.
- Upload and release an online course.

4.9. Instant message communication tool

Instant message communication can be very effective and quick tools to promote a collaborative environment. The instant message will provide an online community that will follow the community guideline previously created.

- Define which tools will be adopted.
- Create content and channels.
- Designate moderators for each channel.
- Create a support team for each HUB.

4.10. RACI Matrix

The RACI (responsible – accountable – consulted – informed) matrix in Table 3 will provide information about responsibilities related to all activities in chapter 4 of this communication plan for tool dissemination. Some of them are TBD (to be defined) status because the document still lacks approval.

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Table 3 – RACI

Task / Activity	Responsible	Accountable	Consulted	Informed
4.1 a	HUB South America	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.1 b, c	ISARIC EB	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.2 a, b	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.2 c	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.2 d, e	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.3	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.4	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.5	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.6	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.7 a, b, d	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.7 c	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.7 e	TBD	HUB South America	TBD	TBD
4.8 a b c e	ISARIC Platform	All HUBs	TBD	TBD
4.8 d	All HUBs	ISARIC Platform	TBD	TBD
4.9 a	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.9 b	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
4.9 c d	ISARIC Platform	TBD	TBD	TBD

Source: Created by ISARIC HUB South America, 2025.

The RACI matrix will be updated on the final version of this document after approval.